was playing without a bat sponsor. Most players had ‘Four Square’ or ‘Wills’ on their bats, but my determination not to endorse a tobacco brand meant I was playing without a bat sticker. A few months before the tournament started, a leading multinational, which had just entered India, had approached me but talks had not progressed much. I had quoted an amount to them to which they did not agree. I was therefore surprised when, in the middle of the game, the managing director of this company came over to meet me and suggested that if I put his company’s sticker on my bat there and then, they would pay me any amount I wanted.

I turned down the offer. I was clear I wanted no distractions in the middle of a tournament. I did not want an alien element on my bat, something I had not come to terms with, to catch my eye while I was batting. It might have affected my rhythm. I said I would put a sticker on my bat when *I* wanted to and not when I was asked to do so. I had done well without a bat sticker up till then and, like most sportsmen (though not all care to acknowledge it), I was superstitious about such things. I did not want to risk making changes when I was batting well. The bat sticker could wait.

Towards the closing stages of the tournament, my friend and manager Mark Mascarenhas, head of the sports management company WorldTel, mentioned to me that he had lined up MRF, the well-known Indian car tyre brand, as a bat sponsor but the deal would only come into effect *after* the tournament. Mark, who was based in Connecticut and had made a name for himself by winning the television rights of the 1996 World Cup, knew my concerns well and never pushed me into doing anything against my wishes. His ability to understand and appreciate my issues made him a really special person. Mark was more a friend than a manager and I was able to trust him fully with all my needs. While he changed the nature of player endorsements in cricket by bringing a string of major corporates to the table, he did so without ever forcing a particular endorsement on me.

I first met Mark in Sri Lanka in 1995 and it was Ravi Shastri who introduced us. Ravi said to me that here was a man who could shake things up and had a very interesting proposition for me. As soon as I met him I was impressed by his professionalism and attention to detail. Mark never left anything to chance. We were really close and even went on a couple of family holidays together. On one of these holidays, to Coonoor in South India, we had a fantastic time eating all the local delicacies and